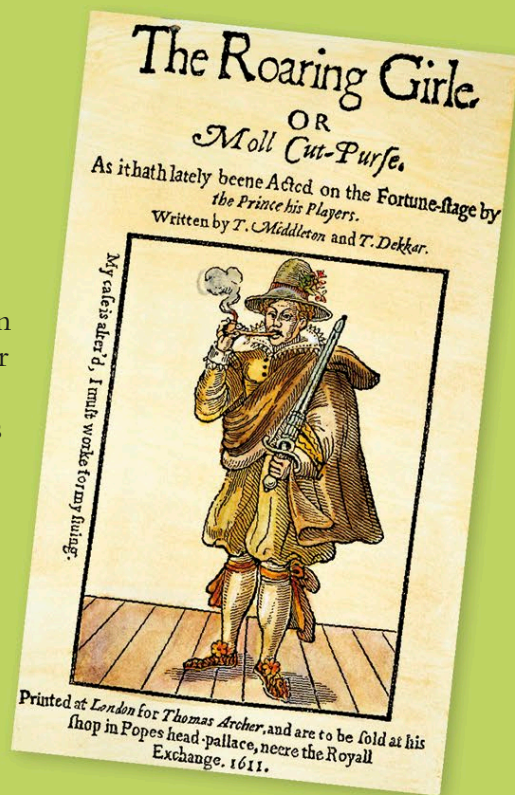


then killed a string of husbands, such as Belle Gunness and Otilie Klimek; others, such as Japanese midwife Miyuki Ishikawa, took in babies from struggling mothers for a fee, then murdered them rather than take them to a new home as promised. Murders by women have most often taken place in their capacity as caregivers—to children and the elderly—or to lovers (or rapists) as “crimes of passion,” with motives from jealousy to self-defense. Unusually, in the 1930s, the notorious Ma Barker, supported the Baker-Karpis gang, a murderous band of bank robbers led by her four sons that operated across the US.

Since the 1980s, historians have highlighted the gendered nature of crime, with some acts designated as “male” or “female,” and punishments divided along gender lines: women, for example, received the most convictions for witchcraft (see pp. 120–121), whether or not they were guilty. The means by which women have killed have differed from those of men. From the 1st-century Roman Locusta to the “Lonely Hearts Killer” Nannie Doss in the 20th century, women often used poison, a silent weapon that is easy to slip into food while it is being prepared. Others have used more “male” methods of brute force—such as Juana Barraza, who was imprisoned in 2008 for bludgeoning or strangling to death between 42 and 48 elderly women.

Historically, some women only committed crimes with a male accomplice. American outlaw Bonnie Parker was tempted into a (much-romanticized) life of robbery and murder when she met Clyde Barrow in the 1920s. Later, in the 1960s, notorious female killer Myra Hindley was imprisoned for her part in the abduction, torture, and killing of children on the British Moors. Hindley blamed her actions on her “abusive” partner Ian Brady; however, while she might not have killed without Brady’s influence, she was an active participant in the murders.



#### ▲ The roaring girl

Mary Frith, known as “Moll Cut-Purse,” was a pickpocket and fence operating in London at the turn of the 17th century. She was cross-dresser who wore men’s clothes, and also a bawdy entertainer, both of which helped her to distract her targets.



#### PROFILES

### VILLAINS AND MURDERESSES

**Lucrezia Borgia** (1480–1519) was the daughter of Pope Alexander VI and was born into a fiercely ambitious family. Depicted by her enemies as a seductress who poisoned to achieve her ends, she was also accused of incestuous relations with her brother, Cesare. Her two arranged marriages ended badly for the grooms (the first in annulment, the second in death by murder), but it is questionable whether she was involved except as a pawn.

**Elizabeth Báthory** (1560–1614) was called the “blood countess” because she tortured and killed hundreds of girls at her castle of Čachtice, Hungary. She started with servants and peasants’ daughters—supposedly bathing in their blood to stay beautiful—but was caught after she started killing the daughters of the lesser gentry, sent to her to learn etiquette. She was convicted of 80 murders in 1611 and held in solitary confinement until her death.

**Amelia Dyer** (1837–1896) may have been the most prolific serial killer in British history. A baby farmer (who accepted custody of a child in exchange for payment), she is said to have murdered 200–400 infants in her care over a 20-year period. She killed the children she was paid to look after, substituting the dead child with newer charges if the mother wished to see them, frequently moving premises. She plead guilty to murder and was hanged.

**Aileen Wuornos** (1956–2002) was sexually abused as a child and was a prostitute at the age of 14. She worked on Florida’s Interstate 75, picking up clients on highways and in motels. She killed seven men between 1989 and 1990 by shooting them at point blank range, and became America’s most prolific female serial killer. At trial, Wuornos claimed all of the killings were in self-defense as the men were trying to rape her. She was executed by lethal injection in 2002.

**Griselda Blanco** (1943–2012) was a Colombian drug lord, who was often referred to as the “Cocaine Godmother.” She was a key figure in the drug wars that took place in Miami, Florida, in the 1970s and 1980s. She became known for ordering the executions of her enemies in drive-by shootings from motorcycles, but was assassinated by her own method in 2012, after her supposed retirement.